



BOUNTY FOR BENGAL

- Metro facilities to be extended with five new Metro stations with an eye on civic elections later this year.
- A proposed sports academy in Kolkata
- A Rabindra Museum in Howrah and a Gitanjali Museum in Bolpur to commemorate the 150th birth anniversary of Rabindranath Tagore.
- Shambhu Mitra Cultural Complex of performing arts and a music academy in Howrah.
- A state-of-the-art advanced loco pilot training centre in Kharagpur, an advanced railway track training centre in Beleghata and four multi-disciplinary training centres.
- A centre for railway research to be set up at IIT-Kharagpur.
- A Diesel Multiple Unit factory to be set up in Sankrail.
- A refrigerated container factory on PPP mode in Budge Budge.
- Special tourist trains called Bharat Tirth to start on 16 routes.
- Ten Express trains, including two Duronto trains.
- Kharagpur to be made a world-class station.



BANERJEE AT THE POST-BUDGET PRESS CONFERENCE

with almost surgical precision. For those whom public transport meant overcrowded buses and chances of accidents, the expansion of the Metro will not only bring relief but surely translate into votes for Banerjee in the civic elections. To counter the challenge of her ally, the Congress, in north Bengal where she is on weaker ground as opposed to the southern part of the state, Banerjee has ensured that most of the new rail lines, Matribhoomi Ladies Specials and express trains take a sweep of the north. Banerjee's budget uses economic logic well—even if on its head—to push political imperatives. She uses all the right phrases about growth, expansion, investment, connectivity, public-private partnerships to promote political interests.

The minister has shown that while her hands may be tied to the extent to which she can do with trains per se,

her budget has opened up huge spaces for diversification and employment generation prospects in the shape of schools, hospitals and tourism units. "She has presented the budget as railway minister but as far as Bengal is concerned, she has acted as health, education and tourism minister too," says senior political commentator Suman Chatterjee.

The industry has welcomed the change in tracks. Amit Mitra secretary-general, FICCI, says, "The decision to invite private expertise and resources for deployment in areas like new line development, manufacturing of rolling stock, port and mine connectivity, and multi-layer parking facilities would go a long way in modernising the railway system." Chandrajit Banerjee, director-general, CI describes it "as a forward looking budget that balances the needs of industry and the common man". Sanjay Budhia, managing director of Patton International Ltd

and one of the most high-profile industrialists of Bengal, is happy with the budget. "Her emphasis on the social fabric is what I think has been particularly important. She has also promised time-bound implementation. And we do not see any problem in her charity beginning at home," he said. Pawan Kumar Ruia, chairman of the Ruia Group that owns Jessop, one of the leading railway wagon manufacturers of the country, said: "I welcome the decision to set up five wagon manufacturing units and a Diesel Multiple Unit (DMU) manufacturing unit in PPP mode, particularly in the light of the mention of scarcity of wagons and coaches in the budget speech. I also welcome the promise of a modified wagon investment scheme. However, we'd be happier if the target of procuring new wagons for the next year was increased from the level of the previous year."

But as always, Banerjee's vision is seen as "populist" by her detractors.